

MONEY IS A DISEASE

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Money is a flawed concept because it tries to impart a sense of fairness in what are fundamentally asymmetrical transactions.

The world is not fair.

It's never going to be fair.

Any attempt to make the world fair only makes it even less fair.

"But without money, we'd have to go back to bartering and that has hard limits, because.... blah, blah, blah"

No.

You can just share the stuff you make or grow with your community and they share with you.

Economists spent decades treating Garrett Hardin's "Tragedy of the Commons" as gospel, insisting that unattended shared resources inevitably collapse because humans are inherently selfish, utility-maximizing units.

Elinor Ostrom won a Nobel Prize in economics for proving the exact opposite. Real human communities manage common-pool resources sustainably without price tags, private ownership, or armed police, relying entirely on mutual restraint, local trust, and shared norms.

"But if everything is just free, then why wouldn't someone just walk into a store and take everything?"

It takes a truly diseased mind to even ask that question. Seriously, I feel bad for someone who thinks like this. You need intensive therapy and you need it immediately.

But there's a shred of truth in it, but that truth is far uglier than anyone wants to admit. This gets into deep truths about human nature that are forbidden from being discussed because they make certain people very uncomfortable.

So, I'll explain with a true story:

THE ICE CREAM STORY

The local community food bank is offering brand new sealed pints of Ben & Jerry's ice cream for free. There is no one monitoring the stock or handing them out. There is simply a freezer accessible to the public. At the end of the day, a little over half of the ice cream was gone.

What does that tell us?

People found the ice cream. I did. I took 2 pints.

I could have taken it all. But I took 2 pints.

The woman behind me took 1 pint.

She could have taken them all but chose to take just 1 pint.

Had a rich person become aware of this, you know who would have taken it all. They would have swung open the door of their BMW SUV, walked in with

two giant Louis Vuitton shopper bags and loaded up all of the ice cream and left.

Why?

Because it was free.

BEHAVIORAL SCIENCE

This is not speculation; it is established behavioral science. In a famous 2012 study at UC Berkeley led by social psychologist Paul Piff, researchers put participants in a room with a jar of candy explicitly designated for children participating in studies next door. The participants who ranked themselves as upper-class took roughly twice as much candy from the kids as the lower-income participants.

A rich person has internalized the disease of capitalism. They are so sick that they can't even perceive the needs of other people. They have to be because capitalism specifically rewards this kind of mentality. The system trains them to view any unmonetized, unprotected surplus as an inefficiency, a value leak that must be vacuumed up simply because it was left on the table.

THE SCARCITY MINDSET

Fascinatingly, this behavior also implies the existence of a scarcity mindset. Imagining that poor people are operating with less fear of scarcity than rich people is wild to contemplate.

But imagining that poor people have a greater sense of empathy and greater awareness of the concept of the common good than rich people is not difficult at all to understand. For working-class people, empathy is a basic survival mechanism. Their lives depend on mutual aid, shared goodwill, and reciprocal support within their social network.

Wealth buys insulation from that interdependence. The second someone has enough capital to purchase solutions to every material problem, they sever the feedback loop that requires human connection. The psychological muscles of

empathy and restraint atrophy because money made them obsolete.

THE MONEY DISEASE

Money is an unnecessary invention that metastasized into a psychological pathogen. For thousands of generations, human survival rested on organic webs of mutual aid, communal stewardship, and shared obligation.

Standardized currency did not arise to make life easier; it was engineered to extract tax revenue through coercion to fund state armies.¹

By translating living, cooperative bonds into a cold numeric ledger, capitalism systematically pathologizes human nature. It rewards predatory extraction, breeds a permanent neurosis of artificial scarcity, and convinces the accumulator that hoarding resources they will never consume is rational behavior.

Money does not solve any logistical challenge; instead it creates the very scarcity it claims to manage, eroding trust until society mistakes an accounting gimmick for the only way to live.

SUPER MARIO BROTHERS

The primary game that drove the worldwide adoption of the Nintendo Entertainment System as a game called Super Mario Brothers. It was a side-scrolling game where your character, Mario, had to perform acrobatics to defeat enemies and gather coins. Gathering 100 coins grants one respawn if the player is killed.

The player learns very quickly that winning the game involves gathering as many coins as possible. Imagine playing the game and choosing to leave coins behind that you could have easily collected. There's absolutely no reason to do that.

Mario had a brother named Luigi. Imagine if the game had been created slightly differently. In a two-player setup, Mario completes level one and then

¹ Chartalism is correct

Luigi plays level one afterward. The classic game supports this mode.

The critical change in this thought experiment is that the coins do not respawn between playthroughs. So, if Mario acquires all of the coins, Luigi gets none. Same thing for level two and so on.

Eventually, Mario has 10 respawns available and Luigi still has none. Then Luigi makes a mistake on level three and dies. The game is now over and Mario wins. But what did he win? He defeated Luigi. But the point was to defeat the game. By defeating Luigi, Mario never learns what level 4 is like and the princess remains imprisoned by Bowser.

To accomplish the actual objective of the game, Mario and Luigi must cooperate. In this mode of game play, Mario leaves half of the coins behind during his play through each level. Only then can they make it through the whole game and ultimately save the princess.

UPDATE

I revisited the food bank only 2 days after the events described previously and noticed that a sign had been posted on the freezer that read, “Limit: 5 items per person.”

I asked one of the social workers about it and she said that one person had cleaned out the entire remaining supply. She couldn’t tell me anything about the person for privacy reasons, so I asked if they drove up in a luxury car. “Mhm” she said under her breath.

I then wondered aloud about how bizarre it is that wealthy people have a more acute fear of resource scarcity than poor people do. She stopped me and said, “I’m a social worker. I know.”